

CSS Float Guide

Understanding Float

The float property causes an element to float to the left or right side of its container, allowing text and other content to wrap around it. Historically used for layout, floats are now primarily used for wrapping text around images. Modern layouts prefer flexbox and grid.

Key Point: Float removes an element from the normal flow and shifts it to the specified side. Other elements wrap around the floated element. Float originally designed for wrapping text around images, not page layouts. Always clear floats to prevent layout collapse.

Float Property Reference

Value	Description	Behavior
none	Default. Element is not floated	Follows normal document flow
left	Element floats to the left	Content wraps to the right
right	Element floats to the right	Content wraps to the left
inherit	Inherits from parent element	Inherits float value

Related Property: clear

Value	Purpose	Usage
clear: left	Prevents floating to the left	Element moves below left-floated items
clear: right	Prevents floating to the right	Element moves below right-floated items
clear: both	Prevents floating on both sides	Element moves below all floated items
clear: none	Default. Element can float next to floated items	Allows wrapping around floated content

Practical Examples

Example 1: Float Left - Text Wrapping

```
/* CSS */
.image-float { float: left; width: 150px; height: 150px; margin-right: 20px; background: linear-gradient(135deg, #90c6ff 0%, #6072ff 100%); border-radius: 8px; }
```

HTML Usage:

<div class="image-float"></div>
<p>Text wraps around floated element...</p>

Live Demo:

This text wraps around the floated element on the left. Text flows naturally to the right side of the floated box, creating a nice layout for images with accompanying text. This is the classic use case for float in web design.

Example 2: Float Right - Text Wrapping

```
/* CSS */
.image-right { float: right; width: 150px; height: 150px; margin-left: 20px; background: linear-gradient(135deg, #667eea 0%, #764ba2 100%); border-radius: 8px; }
```

HTML Usage:

<div class="image-right"></div>
<p>Text wraps around floated element...</p>

Live Demo:

This text wraps around the floated element on the right. The floated box is positioned to the right, and text flows to the left around it. This creates a different layout pattern for image-and-text combinations.

Example 3: Multiple Floated Elements

```
/* CSS */
.column { float: left; width: 30%; margin-right: 3%; background: white; padding: 20px; border: 1px solid #ddd; border-radius: 4px; }
```

HTML Usage:

<div class="column">Column 1</div>
<div class="column">Column 2</div>
<div class="column">Column 3</div>

Column 1

Column 2

Column 3

Example 4: Clear Left - Preventing Float Wrap

```
/* CSS */
.floated-left { float: left; width: 48%; background: #3498db; color: white; padding: 20px; margin-right: 20px; }
.no-wrap { clear: left; background: #ecf0f1; padding: 20px; }
```

HTML Usage:

<div class="floated-left">Floated</div>
<div class="no-wrap">This moves below float</div>

Live Demo:

Floated Element

This element uses clear: left, so it moves below the floated element

Example 5: Clear Both - Clearing All Floats

```
/* CSS */
.float-left { float: left; width: 48%; margin-right: 2%; }
.float-right { float: right; width: 48%; }
.footer { clear: both; background: #2c3e50; color: white; padding: 20px; margin-top: 20px; }
```

HTML Usage:

<div class="float-left">Left</div>
<div class="float-right">Right</div>
<div class="footer">Footer (clears both)</div>

Float Left

Float Right

Footer (clear: both)

Example 6: Clearfix Technique (Legacy)

```
/* CSS - Modern clearfix using ::after */
.container::after { content: ""; display: table; clear: both; }
.item { float: left; width: 30%; margin-right: 3%; }
```

HTML Usage:

<div class="container">
 <div class="item">Item 1</div>
 <div class="item">Item 2</div>
 <div class="item">Item 3</div>
</div>

Live Demo:

Item 1

Item 2

Item 3

Container maintains height with clearfix

Example 7: Float with Images & Article Text

```
/* CSS */
.article img { float: left; width: 200px; height: 200px; margin-right: 20px; margin-bottom: 20px; border-radius: 8px; }
```

HTML Usage:

<article class="article">

 <p>Article text...</p>
</article>

Live Demo:

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut enim ad minim veniam, quis nostrud exercitation ullamco laboris nisi ut aliquip ex ea commodo consequat.

Example 8: Floated Figure with Caption

```
/* CSS */
.figure { float: left; width: 250px; margin-right: 20px; margin-bottom: 20px; }
.figure img { width: 100%; border-radius: 8px; }
.figure figcaption { font-size: 12px; color: #7f8c8d; margin-top: 8px; }
```

HTML Usage:

<figure class="figure">

 <figcaption>Image caption</figcaption>
</figure>
<p>Article text...</p>

Live Demo:

This is article text that wraps around the floated figure with caption. The figure element groups the image and caption together.

Figure Caption

Example 9: Float-based Navigation (Legacy)

```
/* CSS - Old technique, use flexbox instead */
nav { background: #2c3e50; overflow: auto; }
nav a { float: left; color: white; text-decoration: none; padding: 15px 20px; }
```

HTML Usage:

<nav>
 Home
 About
 Contact
</nav>

Live Demo:

HomeAboutContact

Example 10: Two-Column Layout with Float

```
/* CSS */
.sidebar { float: right; width: 30%; background: #ecf0f1; padding: 20px; border-radius: 4px; margin-left: 20px; }
.main { overflow: auto; background: white; }
```

HTML Usage:

<div class="sidebar">Sidebar</div>
<div class="main">Main content</div>

Live Demo:

Main Content

Sidebar

Example 11: Float None - Overriding Float

```
/* CSS */
.box { float: left; width: 45%; margin-right: 5%; }
.full-width { float: none; width: 100%; clear: both; }
```

HTML Usage:

<div class="box">Floated</div>
<div class="box">Floated</div>
<div class="full-width">Full width, not floated</div>

Live Demo:

Box 1

Box 2

Full width - float: none

Float vs Modern Layout Methods

Use Case	Float Method	Modern Alternative	Recommendation
Image + text wrap	float: left/right	shape-outside property	Float still best for text wrap
Multi-column layout	Multiple floats	Flexbox or Grid	Use Flexbox/Grid
Navigation menu	float: left on links	Flexbox	Use Flexbox
Sidebar layout	float: right sidebar	CSS Grid or Flexbox	Use Grid/Flexbox
Vertical centering	Not suitable	Flexbox	Use Flexbox

Best Practices

- 1. Prefer Flexbox/Grid for Layouts:** Use float only for text wrapping around images. Modern layouts should use flexbox or CSS grid.
- 2. Always Clear Floats:** Use clear: both or clearfix to prevent layout collapse and ensure parent containers maintain proper height.
- 3. Use overflow: auto for Clearfix:** Modern technique to prevent float from escaping is overflow: auto on parent (creates formatting context).
- 4. Set Width on Floated Elements:** Always specify width on floated items. Floats without width can cause unpredictable behavior.
- 5. Add Margin to Floated Elements:** Use margin to create space between floated content and text to improve readability and design.

Common Issues & Solutions

Issue 1: Parent Container Collapses
Problem: Parent height disappears when children are floated
Solution: Apply overflow: auto to parent or use clearfix technique with ::after pseudo-element.

Issue 2: Floated Elements Stack Incorrectly
Problem: Floated items don't align as expected
Solution: Ensure all floated elements have explicit width and margins. Check total width doesn't exceed 100%.

Issue 3: Text Overlaps Floated Content
Problem: Text runs into or under floated element
Solution: Add appropriate margin to floated element or use clear on text container.

Float Limitations & Why Modern Methods are Better

Limitation	Float Problem	Flexbox/Grid Solution
Vertical alignment	Floats can't center vertically	Flexbox aligns easily
Parent height	Parent collapses with floated children	Flexbox/Grid automatically adjust
Content reordering	Requires HTML reordering	Use order property in Flexbox
Responsive design	Float calculations complex on different screens	Simple media queries with Flexbox/Grid
Equal height columns	Difficult to achieve	Trivial with Flexbox

Summary

The float property was historically used for layouts but is now considered a legacy technique for that purpose. Its primary use today is wrapping text around images. Modern layouts should use flexbox and CSS grid. However, understanding float is important for maintaining legacy codebases and for specific use cases like text wrapping. Always remember to clear floats to prevent layout issues and maintain semantic, maintainable CSS.

Key Takeaway: Use float only for wrapping text around images. For all layout work (multi-column, navigation, grids, alignment), use flexbox or CSS grid instead. They're more powerful, flexible, and easier to maintain. If you inherited float-based layouts, consider refactoring to modern methods.

CSS Float Guide | All examples are responsive and work on any device | Last updated: 2026